Daily Shipping Trade Advisory
Sattva Global Logistics

Date: 04 May 2026, 3:00 PM IST
Web: sattvaglobal.in/trade-advisory

1. Executive Summary

The Indian export shipping landscape on 4 May 2026 is defined by two concurrent and interacting crises. The Strait of Hormuz remains effectively closed — traffic through the strait has been running at approximately 5% of pre-war levels since the US-Israel air campaign against Iran began in late February 2026. Today (4 May 2026), US Central Command officially launched Operation Project Freedom, a naval coordination effort to guide neutral commercial vessels through the Hormuz strait; Iran simultaneously warned that its military would attack any US forces approaching or entering the strait, leaving resolution highly uncertain. In parallel, Maersk published a same-day rate advisory announcing a change to its Emergency Contingency Surcharge (ECS) for Indian Subcontinent to North Europe and Mediterranean trades (services E3W and E4W), effective Price Calculation Date 10 May 2026. Hapag-Lloyd's War Risk Surcharge of USD 1,500 per TEU for all Gulf-bound cargo (effective since 2 March 2026) remains active, and MSC continues to decline new bookings for Persian Gulf origins and destinations until further notice. The first India-linked LPG tanker since the conflict began, MT Sarv Shakti carrying 46,313 tonnes, transited Hormuz on 2 May and is expected at Visakhapatnam by 13 May — closely watched by India trade lanes but not yet indicative of normalised commercial container routing.

2. Key Developments Today

- **NEW — Maersk ECS Revision (4 May 2026):** Maersk has revised its Emergency Contingency Surcharge for Indian Subcontinent to North Europe & Mediterranean (E3W/E4W services), effective Price Calculation Date 10 May 2026. Updated per-container rates published at maersk.com. Action required: obtain current rate table from Maersk agent before booking.
- **ACTIVE — Hapag-Lloyd Gulf War Risk Surcharge:** USD 1,500/TEU (standard) and USD 3,500/container (reefer/special) for all cargo to/from Upper Gulf, Arabian Gulf, Persian Gulf. Effective 2 March 2026; no end date stated.
- **ACTIVE — MSC Gulf Booking Suspension:** MSC continues to decline new bookings for Persian Gulf origins and destinations until further notice. Ongoing since March 2026.
- **DEVELOPING — US Project Freedom:** US CENTCOM launched today (4 May) to guide neutral ships through Hormuz. Iran has warned of military response. Commercial carriers are watching closely but have not announced resumed Hormuz transits.
- **NOTABLE — MT Sarv Shakti Hormuz Transit:** India-linked LPG tanker (46,313 tonnes) cleared Hormuz on 2 May 2026 — first India-linked tanker through since the blockade began. ETA Visakhapatnam: 13 May 2026. War-risk insurance premiums on Hormuz transits: 0.2–0.4% of vessel value per transit (up from 0.125% pre-conflict).
- **CONTEXT — Red Sea:** Houthi attacks continue. Cape of Good Hope remains the default routing for India–Europe services, adding 10–14 days and USD 200–400/TEU in extra fuel/operating costs.
- **CONTEXT — Transshipment Hubs:** Colombo congestion has eased to ~31% (down from 50% peak); Singapore at ~28% (down from 48%). Both hubs have available capacity for Indian export cargo.

3. Carrier-Specific Updates

Maersk	DISRUPTED

Rate advisory published 4 May 2026: Change to Emergency Contingency Surcharge for Indian Subcontinent to North Europe & Mediterranean (E3W and E4W services), effective PCD 10 May 2026. Updated per-container rates published in full advisory at maersk.com. Exporters should request the current rate table from their Maersk representative before finalising bookings departing on or after 10 May. Bookings from JNPT, Mundra, and Chennai to North Europe and Mediterranean continue to be accepted.

Hapag-Lloyd

DISRUPTED

War Risk Surcharge (WRS) active since 2 March 2026 for all cargo to/from the Upper Gulf, Arabian Gulf, and Persian Gulf — covering Iraq, Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Oman, UAE, Yemen, and Saudi Arabia (Dammam and Jubail). Rates: USD 1,500/TEU standard containers; USD 3,500/container for reefer and special equipment. Applies to all bookings issued on or after 2 March 2026, cargo already booked but not yet shipped, and cargo on the water but not yet discharged. No end date announced. Source: hapag-lloyd.com advisory dated 1 March 2026.

MSC

SUSPENDED

Not accepting new bookings for cargo moving to or from the Persian Gulf until further notice. Assessing each voyage individually for cargo already in transit. Restriction in place since March 2026; no lifting announcement issued as of this update.

All Carriers

DIVERTED

Strait of Hormuz operating at approximately 5% of normal commercial traffic volume. Cape of Good Hope remains the default routing for all services previously transiting Hormuz or the Arabian Gulf, adding 10–14 days transit time and USD 200–400/TEU additional fuel and operating costs. No carrier has announced resumption of regular Hormuz container transits as of 3:00 PM IST, 4 May 2026.

4. Surcharge Reference Table

Carrier	Surcharge	Trade Lane	Eff. Date	TEU	FEU/Container	Currency
Maersk	ECS (Emergency Contingency)	India Sub–N.Europe/Med (E3W/E4W)	10 May 2026	See full advisory	See full advisory	USD
Hapag-Lloyd	WRS (War Risk)	World to/from Upper/Arabian/ Persian Gulf	02 Mar 2026	1,500	3,500 (reefer/special)	USD

* Maersk ECS amounts effective 10 May 2026 not yet extractable from public source at time of this advisory. Obtain full rate schedule from your Maersk representative.

5. Trade Impact on Indian Exporters

Exporters shipping FCL from Mundra, JNPT (Nhava Sheva), and Chennai to Gulf destinations face a near-complete booking suspension on Persian Gulf ports — MSC is not accepting new Gulf bookings and multiple carriers are reviewing each voyage individually. Those routing to Europe must act now on the Maersk ECS revision effective 10 May 2026 on E3W and E4W services: contact your Maersk agent for the updated rate table before submitting bookings for that date window. War risk insurance premiums for any routing via the Strait of Hormuz have risen from 0.125% to between 0.2% and 0.4% of vessel insured value per transit, materially affecting landed cost on India-Gulf commodity and energy shipments. US CENTCOM Project Freedom launched today introduces fresh geopolitical uncertainty — do not assume commercial container services will resume Hormuz transits until explicit carrier confirmation is received. Exporters with time-critical Gulf cargo should consult their freight forwarder on alternative routing via Colombo or Singapore transshipment, where congestion has eased and capacity is available.

6. Recommended Contingency Actions

1. **Request updated surcharge quotes immediately:** If you are booking with Maersk on E3W/E4W services, request the full ECS rate schedule effective 10 May 2026 before submitting any booking with a sailing date on or after that date.
2. **Confirm Gulf routing with your forwarder:** Do not assume any Persian Gulf port is bookable. Verify current acceptance status with your carrier or freight forwarder for each booking, particularly for UAE, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman, and Saudi Arabia destinations.

3. **Review war risk insurance covers:** If your cargo policy does not explicitly cover routing via Cape of Good Hope or re-routing due to conflict, confirm with your insurer or broker before your next booking. Verify that premiums reflect the elevated risk profile.

4. **Plan for longer transit times:** Build 12–16 days additional lead time into orders routed to Europe or Africa via Cape of Good Hope compared to normal Suez routing. Communicate adjusted delivery windows to buyers now.

5. **Monitor Project Freedom developments:** The situation at the Strait of Hormuz is actively evolving. Check for carrier advisories on resumed Hormuz transits before each booking cycle. No carrier has announced container service resumption as of this update.

7. Sources Referenced

- Maersk Rate Advisory, 04 May 2026 — https://www.maersk.com/news/articles/2026/05/04/change-to-ecs-indian-subcontinent-to-north-europe-mediterranean
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- Business Standard — India-bound LPG tanker clears Hormuz, 03 May 2026
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- India Seatrade News — Hapag-Lloyd Gulf Peak Season Fee
- Container-Mag.com — FMC and India DGS surcharge regulation, March 2026